



BUYERS' GUIDE

ESTYLE

ACTIVITY TRACKER Fit For You



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The best project you'll ever work on is you," said a wise man once. Most of us being avid DIYers working on interesting electronics projects, adding a project to work on our health would be considered a welcome move. Especially when there is a technological twist added to it. In this buyers' guide, we take a look at which fitness tracker could be your best bet at getting fit.

The first thing to do before buying a fitness tracker is to figure out why you really want it. Are you looking for a lifestyle tracker that you would wear all day like a wristwatch, or a tracker to help you train for your next health goal or achieve a faster five kilometre run?

Lifestyle all-day trackers are simpler devices that show the number of steps you have walked or run, or the stairs you have climbed. These can show you information comparing the number of active minutes in a day, or even the quality of your sleep by comparing your regular and rapid eye movement (REM) during sleep. Most of the current ones also have software features that let you compare yourself to a group of friends and set up some healthy competition throughout the day.

The training trackers have much more sophisticated features like sensors to detect heart rate, speed, pace, lap times and more.

These features are in addition to everything that an all-day lifestyle tracker can offer.

Features to look for

Once you decide on what kind of tracker you need, it is time to choose one from the various options the market offers. Fortunately, the competition has become so strong today that you have multiple good options to choose from.

Accuracy. As anyone who has worked with sensors would know, it is very difficult to get constantly accurate readings once the device is taken out of an ideal environment. Unfortunately for some fitness trackers, these get one of the most difficult places to work on—a sweaty, flexing, human wrist that always seems to find a way to bang into something. So check whether the device you are considering works as well during a run as it does during your sleep.

Battery life. In most cases, the training tracker would have much shorter battery life than an all-day tracker because of the increased functions and more precise sensors that run in it. While devices like the Jawbone UP24 feature a two-week battery life (it initially came with a one-week battery life that doubled after a firmware update), the Fitbit Charge HR has four-day battery life, and the Mio Link can muster only six to eight hours battery life. Are you prepared to charge your tracker frequently?

Compatibility. Not all trackers are created equal. Some trackers might have very good apps for iOS, but not so good ones for Android, and their Windows or BlackBerry OS support might even be non-existent. Brands like Fitbit have a wireless sync dongle, which is a small universal serial bus (USB) device that can be plugged into your computer to link your tracker with Fitbit Connect. Some trackers like the Jawbone



Jawbone UP24 fitness tracker (Image courtesy: www.chipchick.com)